

Fireworks

Based on explosive gunpowder, show-stealing fireworks have a colorful past.

Celebrating with a BANG!

Did you know?
China is the world's largest manufacturer and exporter of fireworks, producing more than 90 percent of the total amount.



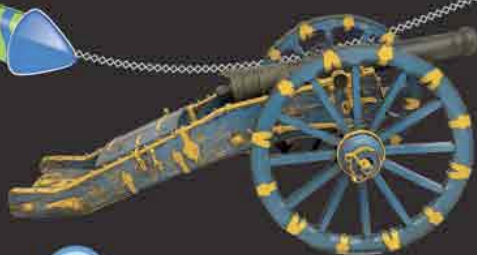
Chinese launch

GUNPOWDER was discovered accidentally when ancient Chinese alchemists looked for a magic potion to create **eternal life**. It was produced by mixing three powders—**salt peter**, **sulfur**, and **charcoal**. When burned, the combination released so much gas that **EXPLOSIONS** resulted. Bamboo poles filled with gunpowder formed the world's first fireworks. They were used to mark **festivals** and **religious occasions**.



Today's fireworks are launched by compressed air, so their displays are not obliterated by smoke.

It paved the way for...



CANNONS containing gunpowder and other explosives were an **EFFECTIVE WEAPON** when fired across battlefields during the Middle Ages.



The Chinese used fireworks to create devices called **FLARES**. These blazing lights could **SIGNAL** over long distances.